

A Kantian Theodicy

When Hume awakened Kant from his dogmatic slumber, he fell out of the warm, comfortable bed of Wolffian rationalism into a bottomless abyss of skepticism from which he was never to escape. For the most part, he had no wish to and only hoped to save Newtonian physics and objective morality from skepticism's ravaging maw. This, in turn, he could do only by taking the subjective turn to idealism, putting the human mind in the place of God and thereby limiting our knowledge only to the objects of its own creation, thereby preserving the *a priori* necessity of scientific and moral knowledge at the cost of their substantiality. Newtonian physics is restricted solely to the realm of appearances, while morality, which owes both its content and its obligatory force to the operation of pure practical reason, seems to both invent itself whole cloth and to stand suspended in mid-air with no visible means of support. At least this seems to be Kant's intention and design.

In this latter case, however, Kant is not entirely successful, even by his own lights. He admits that morality ultimately needs a substantive grounding in something that lies beyond the all too limited resources for knowledge available to us on a strict reading of the *First Critique*, an invisible foundation beyond the grasp of any possible experience. Kant is able to provide only the flimsiest pretext for these required foundations, and few have thought his defense of them plausible.¹ I have no intention of attempting to extricate Kant from the well-known difficulties that afflict his moral theory in this regard. Nevertheless, within the ambit of a philosophy not

¹ However, I will attempt to provide such foundations in a forthcoming essay on the postulates of pure practical reason. Stay tuned.

limited by the Humean strictures accepted by Kant, the moral philosophy outlined in Kant's *Groundwork* contains many interesting and useful insights that can serve us admirably in a number of areas. One of these, in which Kant himself has anticipated us, is theodicy, the justification of the ways of God to man.

In this essay, I want to sketch the lineaments of a Kantian theodicy. Kant does not discuss the problem of evil as such in any of his published writings, although he did explicitly discuss it in his *Lectures on Philosophical Theology*, of which we possess only student notes.² However, there is much more that Kant has to say about this, in his various works, which can be of use to the theistic philosopher. To fully appreciate this fact and exploit it we need no less than a complete reconstruction of the practical philosophy outlined in the *Groundwork* - in outline, of course – supplemented by his other works on ethics and the philosophy of religion.

The Project of the *Groundwork*³

In the *Groundwork*, Kant's concern is to investigate the in principle possibility of morality *as a going concern*, something existing not as a mere possibility, but as something real and actual for us *in this world*. As such, this is no mere theoretical investigation. Instead, it is intended to be fully and completely practical, overridingly useful to us in living our everyday lives. To this end, we need to engage in a transcendental investigation of the possibility of morality so considered, one that reveals the indispensably necessary conditions for the existence

² See the *Lectures on the Philosophical Theology*, Allan Wood and Gertrude M. Clark., Ithaca, NY, Cornell University Press, 1975, 115-121. Kant's discussion of the Problem of Evil bears a strong similarity to the "Irenaean" soul-building theodicy advocated by John Hick in *Evil and the God of Love*, revised edition, New York, Harper and Row, 1978. Surprisingly, Hick never mentions Kant's discussion of the problem of evil. It would be interesting to know what he thinks of it.

³ My interpretation of the *Groundwork* [*Grundlegung* - variously translated as "Foundations," "Fundamental Principles," "Grounding," etc.) is based primarily on two sources: Paul Dietrichson's lectures on this text at the UW, which I heard as his TA many years ago, and the writings of Allen Wood, which nevertheless I will cite sparingly.

of morality in the world as a going concern. From the very first, it seems evident that two such things are required: first, the existence of a moral law and second, the existence of moral agents. Without the first, morality cannot exist at all, even in principle, since in that case there would be no action-guiding moral principles to govern the behavior of rational beings and thus no basis for imposing an ought on such beings in any case. However, the moral law by itself is not sufficient for morality to exist for us as a going concern. In addition, there must exist moral agents, beings capable of apprehending that law, recognizing its applicability to themselves, and conforming their behavior to that law. While most discussions of the *Groundwork* focus on Kant's derivation of the moral law, rather less attention is devoted to his account of moral agency understood as transcendentally necessary for the actual existence of morality in the world as a going concern. In this paper, I hope to partially redress this imbalance by focusing mostly on the latter project.

From the very first, Kant insists that morality must be autonomous in such a way that its foundations and fundamental constitutive principles must be knowable *a priori* through reason alone, without relying on any disputable metaphysical claims or on merely contingent facts about the world and human nature. To this extent, then, Kant has to rely almost entirely on conceptual analysis in order to arrive at any firm conclusions about either the moral law or moral agency. This is a bold venture but not, on the face of it, a hopeful one and the great fascination of the *Groundwork* resides in how close Kant is able to get to completing it. Even if we judge that Kant has failed to achieve his main end his attempt is still a remarkable philosophical exercise from which much of value can be derived.

The first question, then, is the following: "What is necessary in order for there to be a moral law?" Taking the law of (physical) nature rather than statute law as his paradigm, and noting that the compelling force of such laws consists in their universality and lack of